

GIANTS IN ACTION

From Arsenal's thumping win against defending champion Manchester City to the Madrid neighbours playing out a frustrating draw, the world of football saw plenty of **high-octane performances.**

Aneesh Dey and Joan Mathew Jacob

aneesh.dey@thehindu.co.in, joan.mathew@thehindu.co.in



FOR MORE
STORIES

It might be too late for Arsenal to overtake Liverpool in the race for the Premier League title, and the Gunners may have to wait for their first league glory since 2003. However, a football season is not only about the destination but also the journey, and it was a joyous occasion for the red part of London on matchday 24.

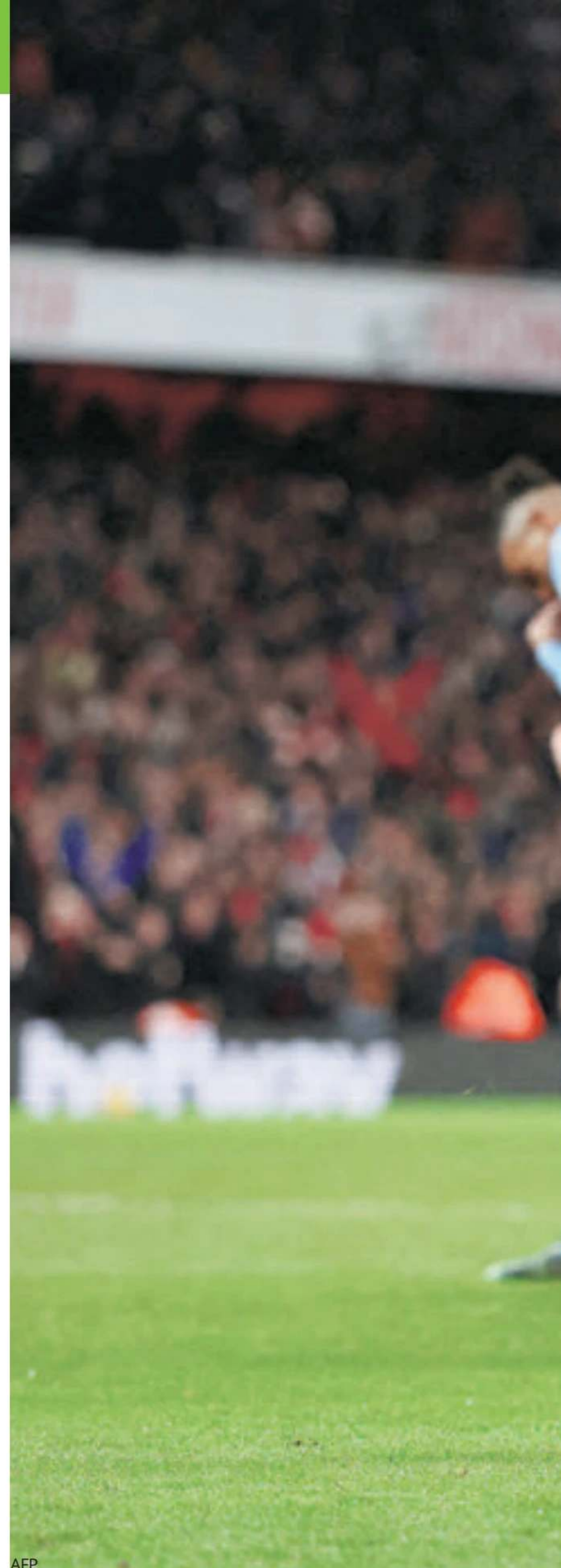
Mikel Arteta's men clinched a statement victory, thrashing Manchester City 5-1 at the Emirates Stadium — the defending champion's biggest loss under head coach Pep Guardiola.

The Gunners began the onslaught early, with Martin Odegaard finding the net in the second minute, which was the only goal of the first half. City looked for a response early in the second half and came back into the match courtesy of an excellent finish by Erling Haaland in the 55th minute. But City's joy was short-lived.

No sooner had a minute passed after Haaland's equaliser than the Emirates erupted into a booming cheer as Thomas Partey restored Arsenal's lead, with City's defence caught out by a well-crafted attack.

Myles Lewis-Skelley doubled Arsenal's lead in the 62nd minute and rubbed salt into the wounds of the City players and fans by mimicking Haaland's trademark celebration, sitting on the ground with his legs folded and eyes closed.

One might have thought this would spur the defending champion into action, but Kai Havertz struck in the 76th minute, and Ethan Nwaneri joined the party in additional time to complete City's humiliation.



AFP

"I only regret the last 20, 25 minutes. We forgot to do what we should do, what we had done through 65-70 minutes. It's a difficult game in that stadium against that team, giving up a goal that early, which has happened too much this season," said Guardiola after the clash.

Title favourite Liverpool faced a difficult trip to the Vitality Stadium against a Bournemouth side that has been flying high under manager